

S05-03 - The Ritual Begins

Player read-aloud

The Keystone finally answers. The Custodian lifts from the ground, glowing like a lantern about to crack.

Scene summary

The Keystone responds, the countdown starts, and the first enemies emerge.

Visible choices

- Protect Custodian
- Intercept skeletons
- Focus fire
- Use terrain

Player questions

- What detail in The Ritual Begins tells you the official story is incomplete?
- Who notices the human cost first, and how do they show it?
- What small object, smell, or sound makes this scene feel real?

GM notes

- Place PCs, Custodian, skeletons, and wraiths. Explain countdown simply and visibly.
- Keep player-facing information actionable. Reveal systemic truth through objects, reactions, and consequences before naming it.
- The final ritual is now anchored in PDF Sablewood: old blue stones, mist, and luminous river logic under the corporate ritual label.
- Manufactured-threat lens: seed the contradiction, do not explain it. The surface goal stays simple and heroic.
- [REFLAVOR/GUARANTEED] Soul-Audit Wraiths bear audit glyphs and say, "Unlicensed soul-resonance detected. Submit for audit."

Checks and rolls

- Group defense Hold positions as the countdown starts. Standard Start the ritual clock with advantages or complications. 15 Cleanly resolve: Hold positions as the countdown starts. Add a concrete boon, extra clue, or improved position. Success, plus the player names one helpful detail or asks one follow-up question. Success, but the GM exposes a cost, ticks a countdown, or reveals a new pressure tied to The Ritual Begins. The full goal slips, but the party still learns a useful truth or avoids the worst consequence. The GM makes a hard move that follows from the fiction and leaves the next choice visible. Spend Fear to tick the ritual countdown, expose the Custodian, activate ward backlash, or trigger Market Correction. On mixed or sliding results, reveal information in layers: visible fact, actionable clue, then

systemic truth.

Clues

- Ritual countdown The ward is activating. Stability depends on protection, not damage output alone. The party can see progress and danger.
- Guaranteed seed Soul-Audit Wraiths bear audit glyphs and say, "Unlicensed soul-resonance detected. Submit for audit." Soul-Audit Wraiths bear audit glyphs and say, "Unlicensed soul-resonance detected. Submit for audit."

Loot

- Ritual Countdown table
- Open Vale residue after completion
- Eligator Scale Shield: A round shield of overlapping slick green-grey scales catches the light like river-water. It smells of deep water, mud, and old teeth.

Mechanics

- Plot So Far: The party is in Act Five pressure: The Keystone responds, the countdown starts, and the first enemies emerge.
- Mechanics In Play: Use Daggerheart Duality Dice as baseline. Use the listed Difficulty and outcome options when a roll matters. Keep trivial actions no-roll; roll only when uncertainty, cost, or danger is interesting.
- Roll Cards: s05-03-shield-the-custodian S05-03 Shield the Custodian Shield the Custodian Agility Strength Agility Strength 13 Agility intercepts; Strength holds the line. The ritual countdown ticks the wrong way. Critical Success: best possible version of the action; gain Hope and clear 1 Stress. Add an extra benefit that follows from the fiction. Success with Hope: the PC gets what they wanted and gains Hope. Keep the position clean or generous. Success with Fear: the PC gets what they wanted, but the GM gains Fear and introduces a cost, complication, or pressure. Failure with Hope: the PC does not get the full result, but gains Hope and receives a useful thread, clue, or safer next option. Failure with Fear: the PC fails and the GM gains Fear. Make a hard move that follows from the fiction. The ritual countdown ticks the wrong way. Use a hard complication, lost time, worse position, GM Fear...
- Gm Fear Spends: Tick the Ritual Countdown the wrong direction or expose the Custodian. Trigger Market Correction, Pass-Through, Memory Delve, or Group Attack when fiction supports it.
- Conditions Hazards: Vulnerable
- Module Effects: Soul-Audit Wraith module effect: Untethered may appear if the stat block/scene text calls for it. It is not a global condition.
- Search Loot Clues: No fixed loot. Offer clue, texture, or hospitality only when the fiction supports it.
- No Roll Guidance: Do not call for a roll when the players have time, a clear method, and no meaningful pressure.
- Escalation: Escalate by making cost visible: time, noise, trust, ward instability, or someone vulnerable in danger.
- Deescalation: De-escalate through respect, care, honest testimony, useful evidence,

or a concrete concession.

- Tv Mechanics Caption: Public cue: The Ritual Begins asks what the party does, what it costs, and who is protected.
- Trait Variety Note: Primary traits in this scene: Agility, Finesse, Knowledge, Strength. If rolls drift toward Instinct/Presence, ask whether Agility, Strength, Finesse, or Knowledge better describes the action.
- Class Community Ancestry Reveals: Loreborne: spots older legal, heraldic, or ward-craft language under the branding. Underborne: notices service doors, hidden routes, and who built the thing nobody credits. Highborne: reads etiquette, class panic, and reputational risk. Ridgeborne: notices stonework, weight, pressure, and structural weakness. Wildborne: reads the land, animals, and local ecological stress. Elf/Ribbet/Human/Giant/Katari: invite one sensory or social detail from the player's heritage. Sorcerer/Rogue/Warrior/Guardian/Ranger: give each class one table-facing way to shine without changing the plot.

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